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Fred Lipsius

Fred Lipsius has fashioned a diverse career in the music business as a founding member of Blood, Sweat &Tears, a composer and studio musician, and as a member of the Berklee School Music faculty where he teaches saxophone and piano. Fred also produces distinctive computer art and composes poetry based on his personal spirituality.

Fred was interviewed in Boston, Massachusetts on July 25, 2018 by Monk Rowe, Director of the Fillius Jazz Archive.

MR: My name is Monk Rowe and we are in Boston for the Fillius Jazz Archive and I'm very happy to have Fred Lipsius with me today. And I've been looking forward actually to talking to you since 1969.

FL: Really?

MR: Yeah.

FL: Some friend you are.

MR: You never call, you never write.

FL: I never called.

MR: But I think it's obvious why but when I was a music student I was listening to you play and we're going to get to that. But I wanted to start out talking about jazz education. You've been in the business at Berklee since —

FL: '84.

MR: '84.

FL: Thirty-three years now.

MR: It's been my observation in jazz education that many professors of jazz education go now through music school, they might get a master's, they might get a Ph.D. and then they start teaching. And I felt like you're a little different because you had some real life experience.

FL: Yeah.

MR: Right?

FL: Absolutely.

MR: Does it make a difference in your teaching?

FL: I can't judge because I'm not sitting in watching other teachers you know. I'm friendly with a lot of other sax players, there's about fifteen of them, mostly jazz a couple of classical, in the woodwind department at Berklee. But I feel fortunate, you forget that I

came into Berklee at a time when you didn't need a diploma. Because if you just were good, or whatever their criteria was, you know, so.

MR: You had a resume though. I mean you had things that you could cite —

FL: Well the Blood, Sweat & Tears stuff mostly. I mean arranging "Spinning Wheel" and placing top 10 in the *Down Beat* and *Playboy* polls, on alto, which I thought was, not funny, not that I couldn't play it, but here I am with one of my heroes, Sonny Stitt, a couple of notches below or above him in the top 10 on alto. But it's a popularity thing and not that I can't play.

MR: Are we getting a lot of noise from that chair? Good. Okay. I'll cut that part out. How have you seen the business change, of jazz education in the last ten or so years because of technology. The students that come to you, they've grown up in this everything is available on YouTube and on Spotify and so forth. Do you notice a difference in the students?

FL: Well honestly the last ten years or so, I've been teaching mostly private saxophone. I've taught everything: jazz comp, arranging, all kinds of stuff. But some years ago I had found out more seriously that I had a hearing loss, probably from Blood, Sweat & Tears, from loud amp. So I got kind of panicky and said I don't know if I can teach anymore. So I started teaching in the woodwind department, fifteen or twenty years ago. So I have my little room with a Yamaha upright piano and two people sit there and that's it. Most of my students are not — I didn't ask at the beginning when I was teaching there, but a lot of them are really, that's not what they want to do is play saxophone. So I do the best I can but I don't get emotionally tied to them one way or the other if they don't come in prepared or whatever. You know, I don't scream at students anyway, I'm just not like that. And if someone does great I say look, you listen to the teacher. I used to go home and tell my wife years ago teaching different classes, I said, "No one listens to the teacher." I'm just being silly. New York silly. But most of my students are at a lower level. Level eight is the highest at Berklee whether you're in ensembles or whatever. And I have like beginner improvisers, readers, some kids, they've been playing for ten years. I don't tell them because I don't want to hurt their feelings but they had a bad teacher in high school or junior high and they were like a band director. They didn't play, they didn't know about embouchure, they just gave them a horn, so they learned on their own a lot, and I don't want to tell them, right, they're like one year instead of ten years. So I have to start from the beginning. One good thing for me is my sax teacher, I'm kind of going off a little bit — like I say most of the students, they're not high level, so there's nothing really to compare yet because they haven't been out there. I don't listen very much to, I go on YouTube, I've almost stopped because I just want to take a break from

new people. Personally I'm at a point in my life I don't really want to be putting anybody down. We all have opinions, what we like, just like foods or, why did I pick my wife? You know? That simple. But as some spiritual master said a while back, and I try to live these principles now, you know instead of bringing out the bad in someone, if you have something bad to say, bring out the good, even if they're bad people. Because it's going to bring out the better in you and it's going to maybe open their hearts a little more and you might change that person. So that's kind of a whole other trip.

MR: Do you have a way to set these students up when you start teaching them improvisation so that it will be likely that they will play something they're comfortable with?

FL: Down the hall I used to teach a lab for improv, beginning and intermediate levels, two different, maybe eight or ten students, woodwind students, flute, you know, sax, clarinet, even a bassoon once. I had to re-write some music in bass clef. And you know to get someone that can even play a little bebop is crazy [scats] it's like no one could do that. It's rare you know. But anyway, but I have about a fifteen page, or thirty page improv workbook that I wrote for Berklee. And like I tell the students the first lesson, "There's about ten or fifteen good teachers here, like myself, or players like myself, and each person has their own way to present jazz to you. I start with chords and scales you know. That's basic in music. Some people might just do blues. I'm not teaching just by ear. That's not my thing. And I've had some students in ensembles that have real good ears and play good, so I don't think I have too much to teach them because they're naturally talented. Not everybody is with a good ear. But I have this book. So I start with chords. The first page is all the seven or eight different types of chords you see in the fake book or Real Book, standard tunes; major seventh, diminished, whatever. In the key of C and it's just demonstrated with the tension notes, the ninths, elevenths, thirteenths. Chord tones and tensions. And then on the right side of the page I have the chord scales that they teach at Berklee. I think Phil Woods years ago did a clinic, no he was playing a performance with Hal Crook, one of the great trombone players, teaches here. And I laughed. He was playing acoustically first of all, in a big auditorium that holds a thousand people. And he says, "You know, kids, it's not all 2-5-1." And I thought that was very cute and funny. Because jazz tunes have 2-5s in them you know. And he didn't go into that chord scales. But in those days they had a tee shirt in black and white that had all 2-5 progressions, front and back you know. But I didn't learn chord scales. It was funny I told some students years ago, I was walking down the street from one building to the next to teach. And a teacher, a piano player, I think it was Mike — I don't want to get the name wrong, so, I don't know if he's still here. He's a little older than me. But he went to Berklee when I did, in 1961. I only went for a few months. And I remember he had nice

I said, "Who came up with chord scales?" And he says, "I did." This was crazy. This was like 300, 500 teachers back when I was talking to him. Now there's about 800 teachers with the Conservatory merging in the last year or two with Berklee, the Boston Conservatory. But out of all the teachers, "I did." And my first book for Warner Brothers Music, it's about a 250 page book on improvisation, *The Complete Book of Creative Improvisation*. I call, instead of chord scales I say "scales to blow off." To improvise off. And I said look, to my beginning students or whoever, whatever level, I said, "You don't have to know chord scales, it's a thing, I use it because it's a helpful tool. If you have talent and you can move beyond that" — when I listen to Coltrane and Bird, I'd notate their solos, whatever I could as I was developing my ear when I was 14, 15. And I'd hear oh, it's a ninth or something you know. Because my original saxophone teacher that taught Stan Getz back in the Bronx, Bill Shiner, he wasn't an improviser. Beautiful sound on the saxophone. You'd be jealous. Just fill up the room with beautiful, old fashioned, with a little vibrato sound. And that's this legacy, I have some of that. I have this sound. I think it's a beautiful sound. I've gotten a lot of compliments, and it's the one thing I feel I can give any student. And I tell my wife, I feel fulfilled if they don't go any further with jazz or anything, if you're getting my sound. Because I used to joke with them I said, "I'm not going to buy your CD if you don't have a nice sound." Because to me you're not showing that you're a good musician. Play classical, jazz, fusion, whatever you want to play, but have a nice sound that appeals to the ear. But Bill Shiner had that. And so I give them a lesson about embouchure. I say it's just diaphragm and the lower lip. I don't even care about the upper lip. Although my teacher taught me to play a certain way. I say you have the lower lip, I said I did everything wrong on saxophone with a great teacher. I used to clamp on the reed. And I had this, what someone called a peashooter sound, in a bad way. It was very small. And this is funny, I used to think when I was 14 years old, I'd blame it on my mother. I says, "Are you really my mom?" Because I'm this skinny little, tiny little kid with no sound. So I'm blaming it on my mom.

MR: Did you actually play with your upper lip under your teeth?

FL: Well he had, put your head down a little bit, you know he taught Stan Getz and all his students. But I don't think you need this other than support and with the slightest support, just be centered in the middle of the mouthpiece. But I have a friend, Noah Brandmark that played with Woody Herman, that had a great sound. And it took me until I was about 30 to have a sound like him, and he was 14 when we met. He was only studying a half year with Bill Shiner and he had this mature sound. I wasn't jealous we were just close friends. But he'd play over here. We'd be silly. He'd play anywhere and get a great sound. And I could do that now too. If you have the pressure from the reed, you know,

through it you don't need your lip. I'm being silly. Or cardboard. And make it vibrate. I was just clamping on the opening of the reed. So I have them start from nothing and blow, and blow as full as you can, but when your lip is on the reed if you're not putting any pressure at all it's not going to vibrate yet. So I said slowly get tighter and eventually clamp the reed. And back off slowly until you are vibrating. And you're getting like, I call it a buzz like in your oral cavity. I can't explain it. But it's ahh, like an opera singer, where you're getting the fullest sound and you're not doing anything, you have enough air to support it, like a good faucet that works, if you want full volume you can play loud, but you should get that buzz on a soft note too, like [scats] you know? Whatever. And they find the center and all of a sudden for the first time in their life they get the sound and they sound like me for a minute. Like on a G, like a good note, not too low, not too high because C is a little funny. A G — I says, "You got it." I said I don't have to say anything more. Now you know.

MR: Memorize what that feels like.

FL: And I'm happy. I said — and then if they're playing a little soft I say, "Look," I play my horn, I said, "This is what a professional volume is." I'm not bragging. And I fill up the room. I play soft too. I say, "Look" I start with a buzz [scats]. And I give them a couple of hints that I thought of, no one told me this. Two things to think about. Because I remember playing clarinet or alto, like it's a little mouthpiece, when I was 14 or 15, so you're blowing into this mouthpiece and you're trying to do something. Think of it as the wall right over here because in the room where I teach the wall is right there. I say imagine you're playing to the wall. Forget about the mouthpiece. You go [scats] sing it out. Or, imagine you're on stage at Carnegie Hall or Symphony Hall, and audience or no audience, you're playing to someone in the balcony. And just sing out the note. Don't overblow but just sing it out and try to hear it nice and full [scats]. Any note. And they do that. So if they get the note once I say man you've got it. It's up to you. That's what you have to do. And you don't have to play loud all the time, but if you're playing in a sax section lead alto, you need to play full or you're going to sound like an inner part. So that's what I give to them. Most of them can't improvise, that I've been teaching. I back them up on piano a lot and we play standard tunes. And in the last couple of years I felt, and I've told the students, I think I've been teaching wrong, jazz. The wrong approach for a long time. There's no right or wrong approach. But now I give them some old tunes, like "Jada" or which "Doxy" is based on, I don't know if you knew that you know. And I point it out to them. I have them play both melodies or whatever. But some of the old standard tunes, the Louis Armstrong in say 1930s, just great, beautiful melodies, and without getting into "Confirmation" and great Charlie Parker tunes, let's start with

helped me with Blood, Sweat & Tears, everything in my life, who I am. Because I like to bridge to people. It's not for the pat on the back, "Fred you sound great." It's because I care about people. So I always believed that Dick Halligan and myself as arrangers for Blood, Sweat & Tears and the original, not quite a leader, Al Kooper, I think we all care about bridging. And I don't think every jazz player does care about that. So if you don't dig it man, you know, whatever. I don't know. I'm just into, and it's not for someone to say, "Fred you play great." I know I can play. It's just to communicate. That's the way I am. Maybe I had good parents. I don't know.

MR: Were your parents supportive of a career in music?

FL: Yeah.

MR: That's nice.

FL: My dad was funny. He was in the printing business with a couple of his brothers. And once in a while he'd say, when I was listening to Benny Goodman, my first hero, and he'd go like this, "You blow that thing." And he would forget it was a clarinet or something. But they were good. They got me a silver clarinet when I first started. I made the music class in the fourth grade. And the funny thing was they played for about 40 of us. There was a piano and the teacher said, "Okay kids. Is this the same note?" [scats] "Or a different note?" [scats] And a lot of kids got it wrong. I'm laughing but I got it right. That's all I remember from the test. So I was in the fifth and sixth grade music class. Mostly violinists. There was about 40 kids. And I played clarinet. And the first year literally I was the worst clarinet player because I was this tiny little kid that loved to play basketball. So when I played my clarinet, I practiced 20 minutes a day. Now it takes 5 minutes to put the horn together with the cork grease and everything, and 5 minutes to put it away. And I want to go out and put on my sneakers and play. So I probably played 15 minutes, 10 or 15 minutes. But at the end of the year the clarinet teacher that came in, he wasn't the teacher there, he came in a private room in the back. He'd teach about 10 of us. But when you're in the fifth grade, a little tiny kid, there are these twins and when we played, you'd play a tune like "Lightly Row" so we'd play like this [scats]. You take a breath for every note. It was cute when I think about it now. So they'd make me laugh, looking at other kids, and I was probably the worst. But the teacher would get us in front of our regular teacher, our homeroom teacher, who was a piano player, a very sweet lady, and we'd play for the rest of the class. Twenty violinists and one or two viola players or whatever. And we'd stand up there and challenge each other. We'd play some tune. And the clarinet teacher would pick who was the best. So at the end of the semester he wrote in my yearbook, "Practice more." It was cute you know. And for some reason, I really don't remember, I started to practice more, and I became about the second best clarinetist

the Bronx, thousands of kids. And there were a couple of kids that played, they were playing sort of Benny Goodman tunes, I mean much better than me. I could barely play anything improvising. I was listening to Benny Goodman, my first hero, and trying to copy a couple of licks. I didn't have any ear, I could play a couple of licks and I felt great. I mean three or four licks, that was it. But as a little kid you feel wonderful that you can do anything. Or play a tune, "Sing, Sing, Sing" you know. But I remember some kids, I started to pass them as I got the next year or two or three you know. They weren't so great anymore you know. I remember my brother's friend was playing "Tenderly" on alto when I first started playing alto, a couple of years later, after the clarinet. And if I could even play the melody, forget about intonation or anything, you know.

MR: They stayed where they were and you got better.

FL: Well they might have still improved but I just — zoom, like "Star Wars." Getting away from the enemy.

MR: Was there an aha moment or an epiphany or something along the way that caused you do get better like that?

FL: Not get better, but two things that I'm going to mention at this clinic I'm doing for mostly rock & rollers, a couple of jazzers, this Friday, a couple of days from now, in Northampton, that I had mentioned to you. I was asked to do a clinic. So I'm going to talk about "Spinning Wheel" and the importance of an arrangement to make good music. That's a good question. I'm forgetting your question. Oh an aha moment. First of all, when I was a little kid I remember being in the crib, I'm the middle kid, and my mother used to play radio, and at three years old, if I remember correctly, I'd be touched by music I'd hear like a "Gone With the Wind" theme on the French horn [scats] you know. And I don't know if I cried, I mean I was just a little kid, but music has always been there. And two guys from Blood, Sweat & Tears, Lew Soloff, who you'll probably mention later, and Alan Rubin, who sat in with the band and played on "Spinning Wheel" when Chuck Winfield was out. He had a problem with his lip or his son was born or something, so Alan played on "Spinning Wheel." But those two guys, somewhere during the time I was with Blood, Sweat & Tears, they said, "You're a natural, Fred." I don't know that they knew my background but they said like, "No one made you practice." I said, "That's true." You just had the love for music. Like one of them said my dad or mom made me practice or something. I don't know that. I felt a little hurt that they were pushed. Because I didn't have that from my parents you know. My mom used to say, "Are you still in there practicing?" Where I lived in the project I could only play an hour a day because the neighbors complained. And when we moved it was in the lease: your son can only play an hour a day.

FL: Yeah, when we moved to another place. Because someone had complained. They got a complaint, I used to go to school with him, his son played clarinet better than me and influenced me a little bit. But he called me up one day, I'm like, you know, public school. You know, I don't want to go into it. He said — my parents weren't on the phone it was just me. And he says, "You know you're not supposed to play more than an hour." And it put the fear into me. So I had years of being afraid of playing. Even now I mean I have a house, but the lady downstairs is very sweet. She says, "Play all you want you sound great." And she's like two floors away from me. It's just me and my wife. So I have total freedom now. But for years in other places you'd have to wait until they'd go out of the house for groceries, and after playing with Blood, Sweat & Tears and all this stuff — so I own my own house too so it wasn't a problem, but a lot of times there's been that kind of anxiety, that fear of not — being sensitive to other people, not having them bother me.

MR: It reminds me there's an anecdote about Bix Beiderbecke when he was living, near the end of his life, and he was playing in this house where he was staying and he thought he was bothering people and they go, "No, no, keep playing."

FL: We're sensitive.

MR: They like you.

FL: On Coltrane I heard he used to play at hotels, and I tell a couple of students, just fingering for an hour before 9:00 or whatever. So I say this is a real test because you can't cheat yourself. If you play a C sharp major scale, or any scale [scats] really fast, you can just think of "Jada" and play it on your horn and some notes come out quicker than the others, so it really focuses you. It's a great thing. I only did it once or twice. The other thing I wanted to say about growing up, the influence, besides naturally loving music in my heart, not knowing, it was just there, when I was about seven I saw Satchmo, Louis Armstrong, playing with his group on TV, in black & white TV when TV was new.

MR: You had about two channels, right?

FL: If that. I mean it was five-four-three-two — the channel comes on. But I heard them playing and I don't remember the feeling I just remember seeing it and I said, "Mom, I want to do that." I didn't even know it was jazz. And I've told people that don't know anything about jazz you know, if I'm playing at a concert — well I don't want to be a teacher too much — but if I mention that I thought everybody was improvising and at a certain point they are but traditional jazz is you play a melody first, and there's a chord progression, a sequence of chords that follow a progression. And it might be 32 bars or whatever, which is a traditional A-A-B-A form. Eight bars, eight bars, eight bars, eight bars, the bridge being bridging material, or different material. And then you want to hear the last section again, like the A section, like "Over the Rainbow." [scats] You want to

Armstrong and traditional jazz players like Charlie Parker, myself, and all those players, not the out players, they would follow the form of the tune. So they play the melody first or stay close to the melody, and then they would improvise. Whoever was improvising first, the trombone or the piano, and they'd play one chorus which is the whole tune, the form of the tune, 32 bars. And someone would say, "Okay trumpet, two choruses." So you'd play twice through the whole form. It might take two minutes or whatever. But you play chord by chord the original sequence of the tune's form. The other thing is with the 32 bars, I do this a lot, I re-harmonize. I change the chords. A lot of jazz composers or arrangers do that because they want to be creative. I love "Over the Rainbow" the way it is, one of the greatest tunes. But I have my own re-harm for it that I've never heard anybody do. It's not about being different it's about doing what you feel works and opens your heart.

MR: When you're playing on a tune like "All the Things You Are" —

FL: I play it a lot.

MR: Are you actually thinking, okay, I'm on G minor 7 to C 7. Are you thinking that or are you not thinking that?

FL: That's a very good question and I've mentioned this a few times to some students, and usually they don't ask me but I'll tell them — first of all when I was younger, and I'm a pretty good improviser, better than most at 16, there was a certain point where I started to become good, listening, transcribing. I have a whole loose leaf book of solos so I developed my ear which was so-so I think, listening to Charlie Parker, Coltrane. Even one bar, write it down. You know, Cannonball, you know, Sonny Stitt — Bird, Sonny Stitt around the same age, and Cannonball, next generation. On alto, Coltrane and Sonny Rollins. Those were my favorite. Not to negate Coleman Hawkins or Ben Webster and all those other people that are great. They didn't have the excitement of the sixteenth notes and the more modern sound. So I went to those five people I just mentioned. Now when I listen back to old timers they sound beautiful. They're all great. Desmond I didn't listen to too much. He was totally innate. It was too light a sound for me. It wasn't as exciting. Because you know, it's just me. But as far as that goes, when I was younger, "All the Things You Are" I couldn't play that tune too well on alto. I was playing piano too. For some reason the chord progression confused my mind. The first eight bars repeat in a different key and then the bridge is different and then it goes back to the first eight with a tag of four bars. When I play that tune now I'm being cocky when I say this, but I own that tune. There are certain tunes that I've played so much that, and I tell the students, I'm not thinking chord by chord anymore, on piano, even saxophone. I kind of see the chords. I know chords very well. But I'm hearing the whole line for four or eight bars when I

know the scene is coming up. Like if you're in a boat and you're going out to a destination, you know what you are seeing. You can see it, or imagine getting off the boat and walking in the sand and you reach the hotel or something. Whatever. I can kind of see that.

MR: You can play or think a few measures ahead?

FL: [Scats] You know I just keep going. And it's not about playing a lot of notes but I can do that and I show students, "Look, a good lick, Miles Davis played [scats]" — it sounds hip but it's just as good as playing twenty notes. The other weird thing for me, and again I'm not bragging about it I just told a few people, if they even understand, something happened to me. You get older and things change, just life experience, I can't even explain it. But maybe in the last ten years, I can't even measure that. I can play long on piano and saxophone, long sixteenth note phrases. Whereas before I copied Sonny Stitt or whoever, and I had his licks plus a couple of mine, maybe I dovetailed them together but there was a stopping point, like a wall that came up [scats]. But now I can play two or three times longer. It's like there's no barrier. It's like the wall got broken in the iron curtain or something. It's crazy. And it's not a bragging thing, I just — it's like string players can play forever. It's not a breath thing unless I ran out of breath. I can just play longer now and there's more freedom. I said wow, that's crazy. And I don't do it on purpose but it's just like, no barrier.

MR: Do you think that's more up in your head than it is figures?

FL: I just — a gift from God. I don't know what else to say. And I never have to use it because I tell people, when I listen to Art Tatum, the only album I ever owned by him was "Piano Begins Here." And I say it should be called "Piano Begins Here and Ends Here." You know. I'm joking. But I don't think there's ever been a piano player like him. I mean Oscar Peterson is close. But for me, sometimes now he plays too many notes, both of them. I can't do it, I'm just saying, my point with the students is if you heard me and were knocked out by my piano playing, or Herbie Hancock or anybody, and they kept playing sixteenth notes all the time, to me it'd get boring. You need variety. So [scats] or patterns [scats]. There's any and everything goes. I mean go back to the classical composers. And I say this. Look as much as I love Charlie Parker, I'm not, what's the word, a jazz historian. I can't talk about the history too much, only the people I loved and some stories I heard but I can't talk about their life and I don't plan to. But Charlie Parker to me may be the greatest improviser of his day and he influenced everybody on all instruments, not to negate Art Tatum, but he to me was a master compiler. It was very interesting, I thought about this, because he took all the tunes of the day and all the classical he heard, and whatever other kind of music he heard, and he was

pick all these little things and play them in any key and put them together, like Ella Fitzgerald and Mel Torme a little bit. Maybe not as much as Bird you know. And that was the thing of the day. Sonny Stitt and a couple of people, they would play, you know, whatever it is, a classical piece [scats] I don't know what the piece that was, but Sonny Stitt plays that. But Bird would, and I noticed Charlie Parker, I only noticed this about eight years ago, on rhythm changes, the first eight bars of rhythm changes, usually in the key of G on alto, he would make a quote from a famous piece, jazz or classical. You know [scats]. Humoresque, but he put it doing this tempo, and he'd [scats] you know he'd jazz it up and it was incredible. Then he'd play his licks after that and dovetail it together. You know. It would go on —

[microphone displaced] Ooh I dropped this

MR: Okay we were talking about —

FL: Charlie Parker.

MR: Charlie Parker.

FL: And I was saying he was a master compiler I think. I loved watching his interview with Paul Desmond. There's something that really touched my heart, for whatever he was with the drugs and everything. And you know Desmond is saying, "You've gone way beyond all of us." And he said, "Well I practice ten hours a day." But he didn't practice ten hours a day for twenty years. It was only a few years. He died at 35 or whatever. But he said, and he said it very graciously with a little smile on his face if you look at that video, he says, "I just try to give the people something for the people." And I said wow, that's so beautiful. And he's just playing so melodic, and of course he played a lot of fast stuff. He wasn't showing off. And then he'd just play a little phrase with some vibrato and it melts your heart. So he had everything. You know? And so getting back to a little of what I was mentioning before, for me, I had a fake book, the original brown fake book with hundreds of tunes in it, spiral bound, and I used to play it with a friend of mine named Hugh Young and me, we used to play clarinet duets. We'd get together and we'd go [scats]. He'd play that and because I knew chords a little better than my friend, he had a much better ear and much better sound, which I never got a great sound on clarinet. And he improvised a little better. He used to play with the Lawrence Welk Show when Pete Fountain came on. I couldn't do that yet. His dad was real proud. He was only 13, I was 14.

MR: He played along with it?

FL: He played along already when he was 12 or 13 years old. I couldn't do that. He had a good ear. Maybe not perfect pitch. But then I knew chords and I started to get better as an improviser, as I listened to the greatest — that's the thing, I listened to the greatest players. So the melodic thing. So when I'm playing with his he's playing a melody and

thirteenths whatever. (There's no sharp thirteenth, sharp eleventh). But I would play a note [scats]. And then we'd improvise a little bit and we recorded, when recorders first came out, these big heavy recorders. Like "My Fair Lady," my parents had that, we recorded that. So we, and the other thing two with me, my dad was an artist as a hobby. Cartoonish caricature kind of things. So I was pretty good in art, better than most kids. And I made a fake book, a B flat fake book for tenor and clarinet, which I read out of. The two of us would read this. And it was, all the melodies were in black ink with the real ink, not Pentel or anything. And the titles and chords are in colored pencils with ruler I'd use, so it was very neat. So I had about a hundred tunes. I was very meticulous, disciplined, crazy that way. But my point with melody is, because I learned all these melodies from the fake book and we played these and I heard all the melodies, even waltzes that might have been a little corny, I mean if you wrote the tune you'd be a millionaire, but all the old tunes, and then I had one of the first play-a-longs with the guitar strum [scats] and I'm play the clarinet and I'd swing, uh squeak I mean. But I was so happy at 13 years old to be able to play a melody like these professionals. So if you could play a couple of licks that you copied, I don't even remember. So that was the thing why I think I was really good as one of, as a pick, to happen to be one of the arrangers with Blood, Sweat & Tears as with Dick Halligan.

MR: That's a great story. And actually I wanted to read, I was able to do an interview with Lew Soloff a number of years ago. And here's what he said, partly —

FL: You can repeat it.

MR: Yeah. He's saying —

FL: I'm kidding.

MR: Lew said, "I'm saying the real creative force in that band was a particular arranger named Lipsius. Halligan also, but Lipsius was the prime creative arranger in the band. And he's kind of a shy, laid back sort, and he would bring in this chart or that chart." And he really loved your writing. And he finished by saying, "Instead of saying okay we'll do this, okay we'll record this, it was like some members would say, 'man that's no good, no, no good.' And he finally stopped." That was his take on you.

FL: He finally stopped?

MR: He said you finally stopped because the people in the band that were not supportive of your arranging I guess, or something like that.

FL: Not the arranging, I was slow. I was a slow arranger. Dick went to Manhattan School of Music. I'm very close with Dick. And he's a great arranger by the way. I spoke to him some years ago and I said, we were just talking and I said, "I was slow. I went to Berklee a couple of months and I left." You know so I wrote one chart, "There Will Never Be

was. Most — I'm a self-taught arranger. And I'm self-taught on the piano. I feel like a little kid. You know Dino Govoni who teaches, he's a very good saxophone player across the hall from me at Berklee. I played piano once in his room, I was trying out the piano in his room. We all have pianos. And I played for about twenty minutes. He was smiling. He says, "Fred, when you play you're like a little kid." He said, and he loves me on saxophone, alto or tenor. He says, "If I could play piano like you I'd give up my saxophone." I was crying you know. He's looking at me, like he was smiling, just like an innocent little kid. He says — and I've had other people say that. I don't — I can't look at myself and I'm not — I'm just, it's just very natural. I play totally incorrect, Mozart fingering no. I play like a crab. Crab fingers. Sometimes they get a voicing. But I'm very relaxed so I can play very fast. I can't do what Chick and all the other people do, but I have my own style. No one sounds like me. It's not bragging it's just the way, from playing and playing and playing. That's like what the guitar player we talked about, just keep doing it.

MR: Bucky.

FL: Find your thing. So I play a certain — I'm looking at my students, my saxophone students, "How do you play like that." I said, "I just kept playing over the years." And I'm talking and I go [scats] you know four octaves down on some kind of pentatonic thing. If it's in my fingers, in the last ten years, I got it. And with weird, crab-like fingerings. And I'm looking. I'm just being silly.

MR: Hey that's okay. Thelonious Monk didn't have the greatest hand technique, right?

FL: But getting back to Lew. I was a slow arranger so a couple, I'm not going to mention any people, but I did maybe one-third of the charts. Dick was very quick. And three or four of the charts like I couldn't finish. I got very emotional because I didn't have a technique like Dick was talking about you know. He had to write for strings for the week. His assignment, or a choral thing, you know, voices. And I didn't have to do that at Berklee, maybe once or twice so I didn't get over that. So I was very slow usually. "Spinning Wheel" was written in one afternoon. That's crazy. And I told my wife, whose favorite band was Blood, Sweat & Tears and she's from Japan. And I said I wrote that in one afternoon. I wasn't bragging I just said I usually take a month like Bobby Brookmeyer or someone I've heard is very slow but he writes great. So if it takes me that long it takes me that long you know. But the thing about Lew, and I played at his memorial with Randy Brecker, I played a tune that he loved, a ballad called "Folk Song" that I wrote when I was 17, 18 years old. A slow piece. He loved it but he never recorded it. And I was going to play "Over the Rainbow" solo piano for his memorial a few years ago and I found out that no one else was playing solo. You know the Gil Evans band and actually Lew's ex-

going to perform. I thought it'd be an ego trip, I'm the one guy coming from Boston down to the New York area, everybody else, there's about fifteen musicians, Wynton Marsalis played also. But most people came from New York. And when they asked me to play, Noah Evans who was in charge of recruiting people, and Steve Shaffer. Is it Steve?

MR: Paul Shaffer.

FL: Paul Shaffer. They were getting people. So the first group of people on the list in an email, and I'm thinking I'd like to play "Over the Rainbow" because I've played it and it really opens people's hearts with my reharm and the way I play it. But I don't want to show off and being the only guy that's — you know I'm coming down and I'm just going to play by myself. They asked me to play with the band. And I have hearing loss so I didn't want to play with anybody, loud music. I don't care how good they play I just don't want to hurt my ears anymore. I want to hear the birds still. Because I have some serious hearing loss in the high range. But then there was another list a week later as they were getting this list together and I said, Randy, I said let me do something with Randy. Maybe "Over the Rainbow" with my reharm I sent him, and this tune "Folk Song." So Randy said, "Let's do 'Folk Song.'" So we did that. Lew — we were pretty close. But honestly when I've been with Lew at some clubs, like I was mentioning before the interview, when I went down to New York one of the last times I played with him I sat in. I asked if I could play. He was playing in a jazz club, only a few people there. But outside the club I'm there with a friend of mine and he was telling other people, he said, "Fred's the guy." The false — I take it but Dick Halligan was a great arranger, David Clayton Thomas to me was the best pop singer, he had the strongest voice. He could sing any kind of music. I love Paul McCartney and Stevie Wonder, Stevie Winwood, but David could sing any kind of music you know.

MR: There was a big, fairly significant turnover after the first Blood, Sweat & Tears record. Did that come internally or was that partly from like Columbia Records.

FL: I don't think they had anything to do with that. Look, I'm one-ninth. And I tell people, I've written stories about Blood, Sweat & Tears, little things, without putting anybody down because I just don't want to do that. Because there's different views. I'm not perfect you know. So there's people that don't like me as a teacher. They don't like me because I'm a nice guy, they don't like my smile. It's just the way it is. You know, that's the way it is. Other people think I'm the best piano player in the world, or, really, or at Berklee out of a lot of good piano players. And I never studied you know. Some good people. So it's crazy. I've heard people say, "You play better than Charlie Parker." And I don't cry — I was playing a couple of years ago in a room and Frank Tiberi, who's a great saxophone player. He's 88, 89 years old now. He's still bopping around. Plays

or something but I was playing my alto and he was in another room down the hallway at Berklee. Everybody else was gone, it was nighttime. And he was nice enough to fix my horn or do something. So I was really up on playing my horn. I wasn't playing all the time, but it just felt great. So I go into his room and I played a couple of notes, which he has rarely heard me play. And he said, I'm being silly now, but he says, "What kind of reed you got? What kind of mouthpiece you got?" I said, "Frank, it's not the mouthpiece." And he's a great player. It's like I play good. It's not — it's me. If I'm out of shape I might sound worse. But you should know that.

MR: Getting back to your writing charts, when you'd bring a chart to the band and read it down, did it usually come out the way —

FL: I'm glad you asked me that.

MR: Because this was long before Finale or something, that you could hear something back.

FL: No. The thing that I was going to mention at the clinic too, to these young rock & rollers or whatever kind of music. Do what inspires you. The intro on "Spinning Wheel" [scats] I'm wondering, is that okay for pop music? That was unheard of, to have a sharp nine chord. Only one other group [sings] "I love you baby" and what's that group? Frankie Valli?

MR: Yes.

FL: In the 1950s they used sharp 9, it was a sharp nine chord I think. But it came out so smooth. I don't think it was ever used in rock & roll before. And I did and I'm going is this okay with most of what I wrote. Totally naïve, and it became a number two. So you just follow your heart. And whenever I've tried to copy too much, do what I think is — it doesn't happen. And then I do stuff that no one else has done. So getting back to your question, I was just thinking about this because I want to speak to these kids for this clinic in a couple of days. And we're going to talk about "Spinning Wheel" and other, what makes a good arrangement. So an arrangement I wrote of the Band, the group the Band, Robbie Robertson and Michael — Richard Manuel. He wrote "Lonesome Suzie." I don't know if you ever heard it.

MR: Oh yeah, it's one of my favorites.

FL: He sings it beautifully, it's very simple, I want to compare the two. It's not that Fred's arrangement is better, I just want them to hear what people do to color an arrangement or not color it. And I liken it to a coloring book, a black and white coloring book for kids. Look, you can keep the picture of the duck the same with the little bits of water, or you can color in the water or the grass green or make it yellowish or make the duck lighter. Whatever color. So that's like brass or strings or whatever you know. So that's kind of what an arranger does, and also you try to enhance. As an arranger, I hadn't thought

Suzie" I was in love with the girl named Susan so-and-so. She ended up in a mental hospital. Unbeknownst to me at the time I was with her, that short time, this was early on in the band. And it's like Taylor —

MR: "Fire and Rain."

FL: "Fire and Rain." He was in a mental hospital or something, you know, he was, and I think this lady he knew I think committed suicide you know. So I was kind of, not comparing you know, but I was very sensitive, and loved this girl you know, was falling in love, I don't know. One of my first loves. And so I wrote this arrangement wondering is it okay. I'm using some Bill Evans licks that you hear the horns playing near the end at the climax [scats]. That sounds like Rachmaninoff or Stravinsky or something. It's very Russian. I have Russian Jew in me. That's not my religion anymore but I was brought up under that. And [scats] that's like Prokofiev or something [scats] on "Firebird" there's a phrase that goes [scats] something like that. So you pick up things. I'm not a classical person but I'm a chameleon like that. So I'm wondering is that okay. So we're rehearsing in this big room at CBS Records where the orchestras play on famous records. And the producer, I won't mention the name, for the album, we're just starting and there's some intricate stuff there, it's fairly high, and it's out stuff. It's not [scats] like Motown licks, but so Fred's writing something different. I'm wondering is it okay but it was motivated by inspiration. That lick I was just singing before earlier [scats] that was like I played it very simply at midrange on piano. It's like a Bill Evans lick. B flat major to D seven to G minor [scats] with a sharp nine in there. Typical for me, I was listening to Bill Evans. McCoy Tyner was my favorite piano player. You know, all these people. So the guy, the producer comes in and the co-producer comes in and he hears people making mistakes with the brass. I mean, this big room. And he said, sort of like a negative attitude like you know, that doesn't sound so good. Like are we going to drop the horn thing? I said, "Please will you" you know I think you were saying Lew, I wouldn't settle for, you know, I don't remember me being like this because I was kind of quiet but if something wasn't right I would speak up I guess, where I normally wouldn't as a person but musically, because the force of music is so strong in me, it has to be this way and give it a chance at least. So I said, "Go in your room and give me an hour and let me rehearse this. When I'm through and I'm happy with it if you don't like it I'll consider that and you consider that, that's another story. But don't break it down right away. You know, what do you know, I've spent a whole week on this or whatever. Go into your room. Leave me alone." And I've done this on an Eastern European tour, we played a Yugoslavia, Romania and Poland. And I saw the film of it. It never came out. But we were doing "Lonesome Suzie" and it wasn't with the producer. Something was messed up and I said,

funny because I'm very bland, I'm pretty laid back. I don't yell at anybody. I'm not — I just don't want to you know. So that's what happened, I spoke up and I don't think I'm always like that.

MR: Well it certainly worked, I can tell you that.

FL: Well I've got to tell you that what happened from that, you know, after we did the album and I left the band a year later in '72, I was with them '67 to '71. A year later Roy Halee that was Simon & Garfunkel's producer, they asked him to be producer on "Bridge Over Troubled Water" and some other stuff. Not all the albums, but he was an engineer. He was a great engineer and he was a trumpet player too. Classical. I didn't know that. He was the first one to double the horns, great ears, great enthusiasm, he was like riding a bronco or something for the next lick that we play or anything. He was very exciting in the studio. He was really with us not just turn it on [snores] fall asleep. He was really with us. So he was the producer and engineer for us too and produced one of our albums, but mostly engineered. So with "Lonesome Suzie." So a year later I'm living out in Mill Valley, California, Marin County, I get a phone call from Roy. He's in San Francisco with Artie Garfunkel who is doing his first album, first tune, and because Roy Halee calls me, he says, "I want you to play piano to back up Artie on this first album, on a Randy Newman tune, 'Old Man,' about an old man dying." A beautiful slow tune, very touching. And he said — I was totally out of shape. I am not a back-up piano player for pop people, even jazz, my time wasn't so good. I'm much better now, twenty, thirty years later. But that's not my thing. But he didn't know that I was out of shape playing the piano. And I took it. So I went out there and Artie's in another room, he's learning the tune, he's making mistakes, I'm privy to it, I'm sitting there. And I did about four takes on the tune. They gave me the sheet music and I played some nice Fred kind of voicings and things which were not typical for rock & roll. Slow, old man. And there were some really hip things but because we didn't have modern equipment where you can paste together stuff we couldn't make a version. So out of the four or five versions I didn't come through. And I made about a thousand dollars that day, Artie took me out to Fisherman's Wharf. I said, I didn't need the money. I wasn't a millionaire like him. I said, "Artie, don't pay me." He says, "Take the money." It was like very authoritative. So okay. So I made a thousand dollars, double scale, blah-blah-blah you know. But the point is Roy — I said, "Why did you call me?" He says, "Your arrangement of 'Lonesome Suzie' is the most sensitive of any Blood, Sweat & Tears arrangement and that was my favorite arrangement. And I thought you'd be great for this tune, playing piano."

MR: Some of the —

FL: It's deep.

MR: I'm telling you, some of that music, those horn parts and stuff just made a profound effect on me. And sometimes it was those dissonances that resolve, and I would go to the piano and go what is that. And so I just wanted to, as I said early on I've been waiting to talk to you since 1969 so I could say that.

FL: No but as you just started to talk I almost start to feel like crying because it reminded me, maybe, of when I was in the studio and we finally heard it back, I've felt this with a couple of my arrangements. This is just me. I'm a sensitive person. Sometimes I don't like being so sensitive. I'm not always. But I almost cried listening to my arrangement because it's very powerful. It starts out with a whisper, there is nothing, just him and a bass. And it builds. And the middle part where it starts to make the transition, we rented a baritone horn, which was the original horn that Dick Halligan played — Dick Halligan wrote, I was just reading his book called *Musical Being*. It's a book about his life. Very good. He has all the details about his life. But he says his first instrument is baritone horn. So in the middle, to make the transition, he goes [scats] if you remember that. And then it opens up and then the horns play that thing [scats] later on. But it just builds and I'm almost in tears. And our manager, who was Steve Katz, Steve Katz was a guitar player, his brother was our manager or lawyer, not manager, lawyer. And he came in to hear us and he says, "Who's singing?" Because David's very guttural. But he's going [scats] like Artie Garfunkel almost. You know? And he changes his voice. It's like how many singers can do that? Singing up high, right in pitch, and then it's really ballsy later on. So but the whole chart, it was like there is nothing like that. And I remember Bob Mann, who's dad used to be the piano player or something on the Arthur Godfrey Show, Bob Mann played with everybody. Well Taylor, James Taylor. He was with him for years. Perfect pitch. And he asked me one day, again I'm not bragging but he said, "Who did that arrangement of 'Lonesome Suzie?'" I said, "I did." You know because it's so different. Like "Spinning Wheel" too. That's what, and people say where's the big band thing? I say, "I listen to Benny Goodman." Dick Halligan listened to the Hi-Lo's, Stan Kenton, all these people. So it's natural, and like I'm also I heard on the first one in the rock & roll books that played bebop and rock & roll on their alto solos. The first horn player to do that. I didn't look in the book but that's what I do. For the last twenty years I hear a little Coltrane all of a sudden I'm growling, because I heard that. I used to hear rock & roll as a kid. It's not contrived, and then you hear all these other players doing stuff, whatever.

MR: Well thanks for sharing that with me. You've made an impression on a lot of people.

FL: Thank you.

MR: And you seem to be a spiritual man, from what I've seen from your website.

FL: That's my first take on life. That's my first love of life. More than music. I was thinking,

my life and I've had a lot of spiritual experience. I'm not bragging. I tell people that look up to me, I say, "Look, there's little kids born today that are more mature spiritually than me, but I've been with spiritual masters that are hundreds and thousands of years old that have been teaching for millions of years." And I'm learning how to become a master. It's not to have any control over anybody. These masters are teaching each soul that's ready and willing, how to experience of God, which is the purpose that we're all here. Most people don't know. That's without bragging about it.

MR: When you look at the current events does, how do you justify those things for yourself?

FL: I'm not, when I say I'm not interested, the deeper you get to love yourself as a spiritual being, a soul, an atom of God, and you start to love people more, I have a deeper feeling for life. I can't explain it. I'm going to cry now, and the master I study with, I'm very sensitive. He says, "I hate to tell you but the higher you go spiritually and become a master someday or in another lifetime, you become more compassionate." I said, "More?" Well, you know, you feel, these masters know the thought of every soul in every universe of God. They know every life you've ever lived, and it's not power, they just have become more with the voice of God, which is the Holy Spirit in Christianity. We call it the Eck. It's God's love. That's all it is. It's light and sound. Interesting, because God's love is actually really light and sound, sound being the highest aspect. So being a musician, you know I hear Coltrane and Bird and all these people. Spiritually to take drugs, that's not the thing. The masters don't advocate drugs at all. I don't need drugs. You can quietly sing a spiritual word. Like "Hu." It's an ancient name for God. And you might elevate yourself into an expanded state of consciousness where you might be on another level way beyond these planets.

MR: Does it come out in your saxophone?

FL: Oh yeah. Um hum. I can't brag but when people heard me when I was younger, some people were touched, other people like Leonard Feather said I sounded like a wet noodle one day, so it could have hurt my feelings. But like when I play "Over the Rainbow" for example, a lot of times people cry. I've never cried that I remember for Charlie Parker. I mean, these are the great, and Coltrane. The only other time I've cried, to be honest, and I won't go into a big thing about this because my wife would, I don't want to drive her crazy. But I heard this young pop singer. I don't follow pop anymore. I'm more of a jazz person. But I've done all that stuff you know, at whatever level. But I heard this girl Charice. You ever hear of her? She's from the Philippines. I heard her when she was fifteen, eight years ago. I'm almost crying now. I hear her I start to cry. I have never heard anybody sing pop, at any age, all famous people, sing as good as her. And I was weeping. I went into my wife and there were tears rolling down my face and I said,

Ellen show. And Ellen said, “Everybody get out your handkerchiefs.” And she was moved. She’s like five foot one, ninety-one pounds, and she sang and she got a standing ovation. She came over with her mother, from the Philippines. And she was crying after she finished, because she got a standing ovation. She had a very rough life. A year later she got a thirteen million dollar deal through David Foster who is the Hit Man, he’s got fifteen gold records. And he had heard of her. He became her stepfather. She toured. And that’s the last person on the tour with famous people from Earth, Wind & Fire — anybody you can name, to see this little girl. But I watched her for three years, two or three hours at a time at nighttime, crying seventy percent of the time. I was going — I’ve had a lot of dreams — I just believe we’ve been together in another lifetime. I’ve had past lives. A lot of people don’t believe in that. She is like a sweetheart to me. It’s not romantic at all, I just have a deep love and joy that’s unsurpassed. And I’m almost crying now. It’s something like — I don’t have any kids. If you had a 5-year-old sweetie. My wife is my sweetheart. I met her in a dream, had a romantic dream with her two months before I went to Japan. And I met her. And she’s been my sweetheart for thirty-three years. And I thank God almost every day to be with her. I’ve hardly ever had a hassle with her. She’s a real — I’ve never met a real sweetheart. I’ve had girlfriends, I’ve been married before, she’s just that sweet. But this girl is very humble, she can sing like an angel, I heard she breaks microphones when she sings, that powerful. She said, “What you hear is my mom. Everything you see if my mother.” My mom is like, I want to be like the best daughter to my mom. And then last year she came out, a couple of years ago, she came out, she just had a sex operation and she changed. Because when she was thirteen, she told Oprah, she was on the Oprah show eight times. Oprah said, “You’re the most talented girl in the world.” It’s crazy. Eight times in one year. And she told Oprah in an interview in an interview two years ago, she said, “Are you a lesbian?” She said, “Yeah.” She said, “When I was thirteen I didn’t tell my mom but I had some relationship.” But when she was seen with David Foster, at fifteen or sixteen, in front of eighteen thousand people with Celine had her sing at Madison Square Garden, she got a standing ovation. Celine said, “She sings better than me” on the Oprah show the next week. Oprah said, “Weren’t you afraid she is going to miss a note?” She said, “No. I knew she was going to sing better than me.” I’m crying you know. So it goes on. It’s just incredible — I wrote to her. It took me three hours to write a letter to her. And I’ve had a lot of beautiful twenty year old girls. My wife is my sweetheart. But she is like a sweetheart. She never brags about herself and she just — but the thing that touched me watching her interview last year, besides saying she is gay, she said, “After I sang for eighteen thousand people and got a standing ovation” or something, “I go up to my room

and cry because I'm gay and no one knew. Like I wasn't ready to tell people." I mean it just breaks my heart.

MR: Well, Fred, you've had an interesting life.

FL: It's not over.

MR: No it's not. And I've enjoyed talking to you a lot, and sort of getting a feeling for the levels that you have been through. So you were curious why I called you for this, and it's partly because you had an impact on me early on.

FL: Well thank you.

MR: So I wish you continued good luck.

FL: Thank you. The last thing I would just say for me, and I mentioned to a few students, this is just me so it's not for anybody, just to think about. My only reason I think for playing now, and just being, is to just serve others. I don't know if Charlie Parker was really doing that, or Coltrane. I don't know and I'm not judging. And I tell my wife, I say I have no other reason to be living now. I mean I love — I've had a lot of experiences, gone through a lot of heavy stuff too with my wife, but I just feel my whole purpose — I've had a lot of gifts in my life, good parents, a lot of close friends in my life, some very painful things, but as long as I can take care of myself, is to encourage others to go on and whatever your dream is, in a good positive way, do it you know. Because a lot of people are going through a lot of pain and I know that feeling. So I'm there for them. Without being cocky about it. That's just in my heart now. It wasn't when I was younger. It was a strong purpose.

MR: That's a great note to wrap up on.

FL: [scats]

MR: Thank you very much.

FL: You are extremely easy. When I was watching Phil Woods to, the interview, I told my wife, I said, "He is great." Like when I watched Johnny Carson years ago, as a comparison, he's great, everybody loves him, loved him. But sometimes, maybe because he was a little nervous or on cocaine or something, he would interrupt people. And you don't really do that. And sometimes if you don't interrupt someone, and you give them something to say and you give them the right little seed you know, they might have a memory of something that they never shared before that might help someone else.

MR: Right.

FL: So I just thought you did a great job, the one time I watched you.

MR: Thank you.

FL: And you were prepared too. You know.

MR: All right.